



The Russian Garden Gazette

The digital journal of the Russian Cultural Garden, Cleveland

ISSUE #18 · OCTOBER 2026



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“He gave all who gave a song”

Tsvetaeva and Yesenin: one circle of memory · Two Poets. One Evening · The Missing Page · 110 Years of the Cultural Gardens · Joyce Mariani: A Rule Breaker’s Film Festival

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He Gave All Who Gave a Song

Yesenin was never my favorite poet.

Tsvetaeva was another matter. I studied her life and work closely, thoroughly and, I would say, very personally. I spent long hours at the Tsvetaeva House Museum in Moscow, waited for the years-long seal on her diaries to be lifted, and worried about Alya, her daughter — so bright, and so desperate for plain human happiness — about Mur, her son, about that whole family, to whom history left almost no chance of an ordinary life.

Katya Vakhrusheva, a friend of my youth and a philologist, knew Tsvetaeva's sister, Anastasia Ivanovna. I listened to her accounts of those meetings, and Tsvetaeva came closer still.



Anastasia (left) and Marina Tsvetaeva, 1905. Photographer unknown.

But what always struck me most in Marina Ivanovna was not the tragedy of her fate. Not even the poems alone. It was her almost Calvinist honesty. Her discipline. What she demanded of herself. Her severity toward the world and, above all, toward herself. Her absolute sense of responsibility to her gift.

And alongside that, an almost unconditional reverence for the gift of others. Wherever Tsvetaeva saw a true poet, a true artist, a maker, her usual mercilessness seemed to step back. She knew how to acknowledge another's gift generously.

That is why her testimony about Yesenin is especially dear to me — a poet whom, unlike me, nearly everyone around adored. After his death Tsvetaeva wrote:

И не жалость: мало жил,
И не горечь: мало дал.
Много жил — кто в наши жил
Дни: всё дал, — кто песню дал.

*Not pity — that he lived so briefly,
not bitterness — that he gave so little.*

*He lived long who lived in our
days; he gave all who gave a song.*

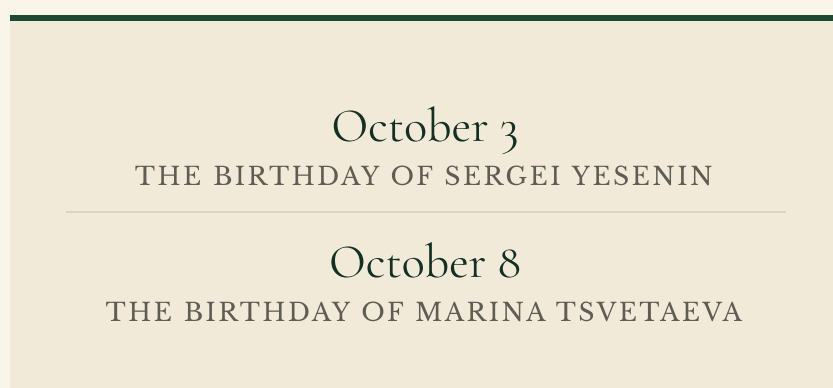
Marina Tsvetaeva, January 1926. Literal translation by the Gazette.



Marina Tsvetaeva's stone on the Walk of Fame of the Russian Cultural Garden. Photo: Svetlana Stolyarova.

Yesenin came to Cleveland. But then, who didn't? Only Tsvetaeva never did. Yet today she is here. We brought Tsvetaeva to Cleveland — and not only through memory, love of her poetry and respect for her life. Her name is cut in stone on the Walk of Fame of the Russian Cultural Garden. In the same circle is the name of Sergei Yesenin. The two stones do not lie side by side. But they are in one circle of memory.

And this October they do stand side by side — in the pages of our Gazette.



But this issue is not about dates. It is about the strange crossings of human lives, and about memory, which sometimes joins people across decades and oceans.

About a December evening in 1922 when Isadora Duncan danced Tchaikovsky before nine thousand people in Cleveland's new Public Auditorium. Yesenin was in Cleveland. And in the audience sat a twenty-three-year-old Cleveland poet, Hart Crane, who had not yet written *The Bridge* and did not yet know how short his own life would be.

About poets and artists who managed to give the world their song, though they were given so little time. And about the fact that history is sometimes very close to us — in an old newspaper, in a forgotten letter, in a name cut in

stone, in a city whose streets we walk every day.

One only has to stop and read.

Svetlana Stolyarova

Editor

The Russian Garden Gazette / Вестник Русского сада



Two Poets. One Evening.

Sunday, December 10, 1922. Cleveland, Public Auditorium.

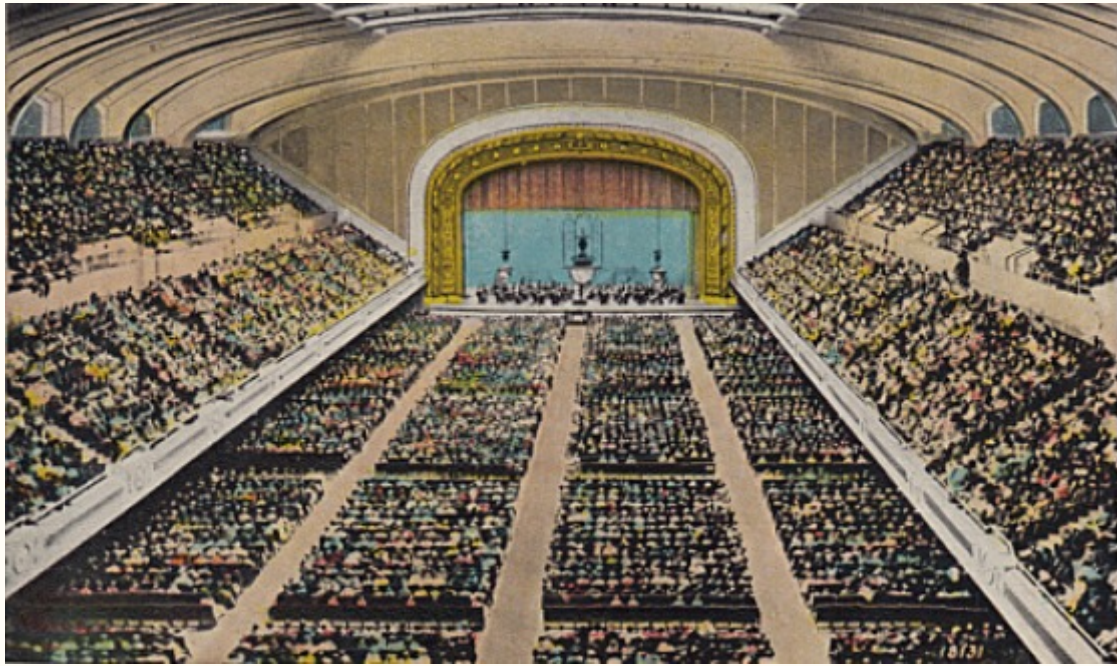
Cleveland's Public Auditorium had opened only a few months earlier. The enormous hall, one of the largest in the country, was built to hold ten thousand people.

That evening about nine thousand are in it. On stage is Isadora Duncan. She is forty-five. Behind her lies a whole era: Europe, Russia, the fame of a woman who changed the idea of what dance could be. A few months earlier she married the Russian poet Sergei Yesenin, eighteen years her junior. Now they are traveling across America.

Yesenin is in Cleveland. But then, who hasn't been: Anna Pavlova, Diaghilev, Mayakovsky, Ilf and Petrov... Yet there is one more young poet in this hall. He is twenty-three. His name is Hart Crane.

To a Russian reader the name will most likely mean far less than Yesenin's. For American literature it is another matter entirely. Within a few years Crane would write *The Bridge* — one of the boldest attempts in twentieth-century American poetry to create a modern epic of its own: of the city, the machine, the bridge, history, America.

But for now *The Bridge* does not exist. There is a young Cleveland poet, an unhappy family home and a Sunday evening. And two of his letters.



The main hall of Cleveland Public Auditorium, filled to the rafters. Postcard, "Interior View of the Cleveland Public Auditorium," published by J. Sapirstein, Cleveland, 1920s (this copy mailed in 1926). Public domain.

Before

Crane writes the first on December 10, that very day. He is staying in a hotel for the time being, after yet another quarrel with his mother. He is oppressed by the absence of his familiar world — his books, his pictures, the Victrola and the records of Ravel, Debussy, Strauss and Wagner. He sits in an empty Sunday office. Someone has left sherry there. Crane writes that he has already had two glasses, will probably have two more — and will then go to see Isadora Duncan.

And amid all this — family quarrels, wine, music, loneliness — comes a sentence that suddenly explains a great deal:

I am unsatisfied and left always begging for beauty.

HART CRANE, DECEMBER 10, 1922

So little beauty.

That evening he goes to look for it at Public Auditorium.

Isadora

The program is Tchaikovsky. Crane would write afterward that Duncan gave the same program she had danced in Moscow. Of what he saw he would say: *glorious beyond words*. And almost at once: *sad beyond words, too*.

Why?

Because nine thousand people, by his account, barely responded to the dancer. After the first movement of Tchaikovsky's *Pathétique*, Duncan came to the front of the stage, her hands held out to the hall. Silence. Crane begins clapping furiously. He cannot bear the thought that from that whole enormous hall not a single human sound will answer her. He hears catcalls, too.

And Duncan goes on dancing.

A CAUTION

This is Hart Crane's testimony, not an impartial report of how nine thousand people reacted. Perhaps the newspaper reviews of the time will one day let us see that evening through the eyes of other witnesses.

For now we know how one young poet saw it. To him Duncan was like a wave of life, a flaming gale that swept over the heads of the vast audience and drew no answer.

Two Poets

That evening Cleveland held two poets of nearly the same generation, who would go on to write about the twentieth-century world in entirely different ways. Sergei Yesenin, twenty-seven. Hart Crane, twenty-three. One had come from Russia — a country of the village, of revolution, of song, of an old world passing away. The other grew up in industrial America and would soon make the Brooklyn Bridge one of the central images of his poetry: a vast structure of stone, steel, human labor and human dreaming.

► VIDEO ON YOUTUBE

A documentary on Hart Crane. Author Documentaries channel, YouTube.

youtu.be/c3YfI_aXBWU

Curiously, a few years later the same bridge would become the hero of a poem by yet another Russian poet — Vladimir Mayakovsky, the very one whose name we have just mentioned among Cleveland's famous visitors.

One spoke almost no English. The other knew no Russian. As far as we know, they never met. And we have no need to invent a meeting. It is far more interesting to set their lives side by side.

Both were born in the provinces: Yesenin in the village of Konstantinovo, in Ryazan province; Crane in the small town of Garrettsville, Ohio. One was the son of a peasant, the other the son of a candy manufacturer. Both left for the big city very young, to become poets: Yesenin for Moscow, Crane for New York. Neither finished a university; both learned from poems and from the city itself. Both came to fame early — and early came to be at odds with themselves.

And both were given very little time. Three years after that Cleveland evening, in December 1925, Yesenin was dead. He was thirty. Two years after that, Isadora Duncan was killed. And in April 1932 Hart Crane, on his way back from Mexico, stepped over the rail of a steamship in the Gulf of Mexico. He was thirty-two.

Of the three people that evening brought together, none lived ten years beyond it.

► VIDEO ON YOUTUBE

The voice of Sergei Yesenin: the poet reads his “Confession of a Hooligan” (in Russian). Ирина МАРГО channel, YouTube.

youtu.be/7ic7dEqOH0o

Nine Thousand

There is one more riddle in that evening.

Nine thousand people.

Anyone who organizes cultural events today understands the scale of that number. Public Auditorium was filled nearly to capacity. Who brought them there?

We already know part of the answer. Duncan’s American tour was tied to the great impresario Sol Hurok. It is Hurok whom the Encyclopedia of Cleveland History names as the man who booked the tour that first brought Duncan to perform in Cleveland. But that is not enough.

How was the concert advertised? What did tickets cost? What did the posters promise? Did nine thousand people come to see the great Isadora Duncan — or the woman about whom America had been reading scandalous headlines for months? What did the Cleveland papers write the next morning? And why did a nearly full hall seem so cold to Hart Crane?

We do not know yet.

But we know something else. Two days after the concert the young poet still could not calm down. He sat down and wrote a letter. And thanks to that letter, more than a hundred years later, we find ourselves once again in the enormous new hall on Lakeside Avenue.

Tchaikovsky. Isadora Duncan. Nine thousand people. Sergei Yesenin. And somewhere among them, twenty-three-year-old Hart Crane, who alone, as it seems to him, is desperately clapping his hands. There is still too little beauty for him. And he cannot let it leave the stage in total silence.

THE MISSING PAGE

Help Us Restore a Few Pages of Cleveland History

The story of the evening of December 10, 1922, at Cleveland Public Auditorium has turned out to be remarkably well documented — and, at the same time, full of gaps.

We know that Isadora Duncan danced to Tchaikovsky. We know there were about nine thousand people in the hall. We know that Sergei Yesenin was in Cleveland. We know that twenty-three-year-old Hart Crane sat in the audience and two days later described the evening in a letter.

But two pages of this story are still missing.

RIDDLE NO. 1

Who Played the Tchaikovsky?

That evening Duncan danced to a symphony orchestra. The Plain Dealer's music critic, James Hotchkiss Rogers, known for the unusual gentleness of his reviews, wrote after the concert:

"All things considered, the orchestra did very well."

JAMES H. ROGERS, THE PLAIN DEALER

A wonderfully tactful sentence.

But — which orchestra? Who conducted? Who organized Duncan's Cleveland appearance? How did anyone manage to nearly fill the newly opened Public Auditorium — about 9,000 people? Was The Cleveland Orchestra, then only four years old, involved? The Musical Arts Association? Adella Prentiss Hughes, who had already turned Cleveland into one of the country's serious musical centers? Or was it all arranged by Duncan's touring impresario?

Somewhere an answer must exist: a poster, a program, a newspaper advertisement, a review, an archival record.

The Newspaper That Lost Its Name

There is another unknown Cleveland page. Among the materials connected with Sergei Yesenin there survives a photograph of Yesenin and Isadora Duncan with an intriguing attribution: on January 1, 1926, it was published in an American newspaper printed in Cleveland. The name of the newspaper is not given.



Sergei Yesenin and Isadora Duncan, October 1922 – January 1923. According to the source, published on January 1, 1926, in an American newspaper printed in Cleveland; the newspaper's name is unknown. Source: Esenin.ru, the digital museum of Sergei Yesenin.

That was only a few days after Yesenin's death. Which newspaper was it? English-language? Russian? Or one of the many papers of Cleveland's nationality communities?

We already have one curious lead — a Czech one.

In the early twentieth century Cleveland was one of the largest centers of Czech life in America, with its own organizations, cultural centers and newspapers. Bohemian National Hall, built back in 1896–1897, still stands today; it houses the Czech Cultural Center, a museum and a library.

And one Cleveland Czech newspaper already appears in our story. On December 1, 1922, the newspaper *Svět* reported on Isadora Duncan's forthcoming appearance in Cleveland and mentioned her Russian husband. Could the Czech press have written about Yesenin again after his death? We do not know yet.

But the Czech lead is interesting for another reason, too: Czech Cleveland has not gone anywhere. The Czech community still carefully keeps its heritage, and the Czech Cultural Garden remains part of the large family of the Cleveland Cultural Gardens. Today it is led by Paul Burik, who was honored just recently at the Gala marking the 110th anniversary of the Cultural Gardens. Perhaps the unknown page of January 1, 1926, is still being kept very close to us.

Join the Search

We are turning to historians, musicians, librarians, students — and simply to people who enjoy a real archival investigation.

We are interested in any documents from December 1922 and January 1926:

- The Plain Dealer, the Cleveland Press, the Cleveland News;
- Cleveland's Czech and other nationality newspapers;
- the archives of Public Auditorium, The Cleveland Orchestra and the Musical Arts Association;
- library and museum collections.

And our investigation has a fine deadline. December 10, 2026, will mark 104 years since the evening when Isadora Duncan danced Tchaikovsky before nine thousand people at Cleveland Public Auditorium.

Can we find at least one of the lost pages by then? And if we do find the 1926 newspaper, the most interesting thing will not even be its name. What did Cleveland write about Sergei Yesenin a few days after his death?

FOUND A LEAD? WRITE TO US

board@russiangarden.org



110 Years of the Cleveland Cultural Gardens

After a journey through the archives, back to the Cleveland of today.

On October 3, 270 guests gathered at La Villa to celebrate the 110th anniversary of the Cleveland Cultural Gardens — a unique cultural landscape whose history began in 1916 with the Shakespeare Garden.

It was a warm and elegant evening, with performances by opera and ballet artists and a very personal speech by Cuyahoga County Executive Chris Ronayne, a great friend of the Cultural Gardens.

But the real hero of the evening was perhaps the Gardens community itself — the people who over many years have built the gardens, led them, held festivals, preserved cultural heritage and turned separate nationality gardens into one large Cleveland family.



Gala at La Villa, October 3, 2026. Photo: Svetlana Stolyarova.

Special honors that evening went to Dan and Debbie Hanson. Debbie left us far too soon, but her contribution to the Cultural Gardens, and her memory, remain with us.

Among those honored was Paul Burik — a longtime leader of the Czech community, a former president of the Cleveland Cultural Gardens Federation and a man who has served the Cultural Gardens movement for decades. After our mention of *Svět*, the old Cleveland Czech newspaper, his name takes on a particular resonance in this issue: cultural memory really does live on across generations.

The Russian Cultural Garden was wonderfully represented at the Gala, and it meant a great deal to us to share the evening with friends and colleagues with whom we have worked side by side for many years.

The Cultural Gardens are not only monuments, paths and landscapes. They are, above all, people, relationships and a culture that goes on living.

And life in the Gardens goes on right now.



A Rule Breaker's Film Festival

*Joyce Mariani on how she chooses the films
for the Cleveland Italian Film Festival.*

The Cleveland Italian Film Festival, which Joyce Mariani founded in 2006, marked its twentieth year this September with three Thursday evening screenings. Joyce is also the executive director of the Italian Cultural Garden Foundation — our neighbors in the Cleveland Cultural Gardens. We asked her how the films are chosen. Here is her answer.

Joyce Mariani

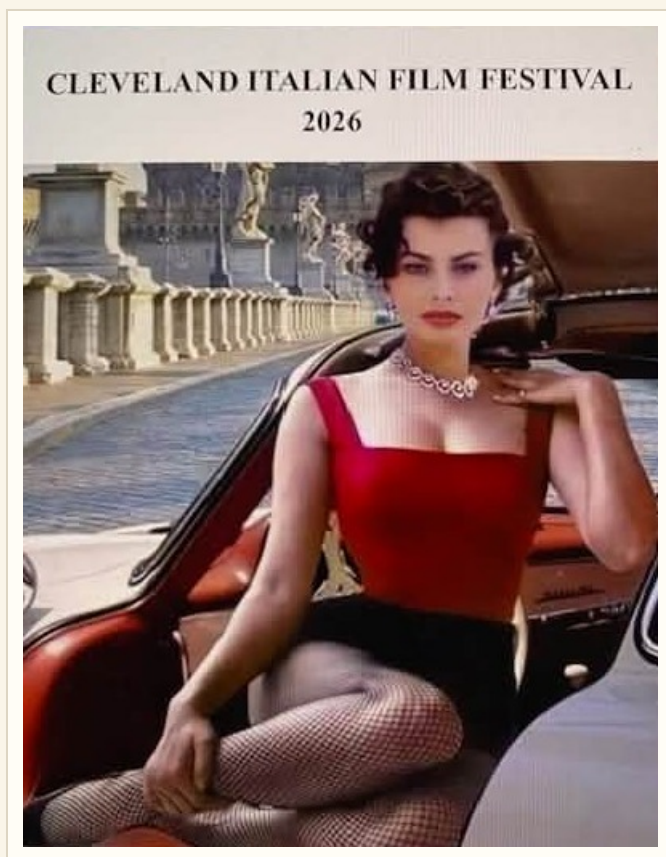
FOUNDER OF THE CLEVELAND ITALIAN FILM FESTIVAL

I was asked how I choose the films for the Cleveland Italian Film Festival each year.

In general, in anything I'm involved in, I'm a rule breaker, not a follower. I respect human nature and how humans are naturally wired.

I broke away from the standard film-festival format of showing one film after another, and chose one a week instead. I never enjoyed cramming — seeing a film every night, or two in one day — and felt that when the festival comes, it should be something to look forward to once a week. That has worked out well for filmgoers.

I also aim for the best films instead of picking a few good ones mixed with mediocre ones. It requires more effort, work and time to view many films in order to find three or four outstanding ones to put in the festival.



*Poster of the 2026 Cleveland Italian Film Festival.
Courtesy of the festival.*

I'm a rule breaker, not a follower.

Listening to the Audience

In the first few years I understood how important it is to listen to the audience. They wanted to be entertained; they did not like violence or depressing films. The audience was seeking an escape from the reality of life. There are other outlets for those seeking that type of entertainment.

Human nature is another element that many try to ignore. The great majority of mankind is wired basically the same: we are happy and satisfied when we experience inspiration, beauty or humor, because it makes us feel in harmony. These emotions fulfill the fundamental core of our being.

Science has shown, for example, that when we view things of a violent nature it changes our blood chemistry, and that our brain has a difficult time separating visual violence from actual danger. That is something I refuse to do, so there are award-winning films I never show. No matter how many awards or David di Donatello prizes — the Italian Oscars — a film wins, if it is full of violence, depression and ugliness for an hour and a half, I'll ignore it.

Comedy, Drama and the Power of Imagination

I showcase Italy's well-known comedians and comedies, and the Cleveland public has shown that this is what they really enjoy.

I also look for good dramas, and for historical films that uncover parts of history that are not widely known. The riveting film *Vincere* revealed Benito Mussolini's little-known first romance, which produced a child and a marriage.

The woman aided his rise in politics; as he became more powerful, he chose to keep her and their son secret, destroying the marriage records and banishing them to psychiatric asylums.

And why do we *need* to see everything and have every little thing spelled out? Great filmmakers like Alfred Hitchcock knew the power of our imagination: they let us put the little clues together, with no need to see every distressing situation. Without intrigue and wonder, a film deprives us of one of the greatest assets we possess — our imagination.





A Woman from Another Time

You have surely seen this woman on screen. And almost certainly had no idea who she was.

She appeared in Soviet films and helped Sergei Bondarchuk recreate the world of the Russian aristocracy in *War and Peace* — because she herself belonged to that world and remembered it from life, not from books.

Anna Timiryova.

Daughter of the eminent musician Vasily Safonov. The love of Admiral Kolchak. Arrests, camps, exile — and an unexpected return to history by way of the cinema.

And behind her name another story opens: Safonov, the Moscow Conservatory, the young Rachmaninoff — and America.



Sergei Rachmaninoff's stone on the Walk of Fame of the Russian Cultural Garden. Photo: Svetlana Stolyarova.

TO BE CONTINUED IN THE NEXT ISSUE OF THE RUSSIAN GARDEN GAZETTE.

Help Continue the Walk of Fame of Russian Culture

Whose name should stay in our memory? The Walk of Fame keeps growing, commemorating people whose achievements in culture, science, literature, music, medicine and exploration became part of a shared inheritance.

The suggested donation is **\$250**. Sponsors' names will be published at RussianGarden.org. A donation can also be dedicated in honor or in memory of someone dear to you.



Zelle:

board@russianguarden.org

Russian Cultural Gardens





Stay Connected

The Russian Garden Gazette is a digital journal of the Russian Cultural Garden, Cleveland — a permanent record of the Garden's life, published for everyone who has ever called it their own.

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This issue was edited by Svetlana Stolyarova. Pieces carrying an author's name are published as written.

Photographs of the Russian Cultural Garden and the Gala by Svetlana Stolyarova.
Photograph of Sergei Yesenin and Isadora Duncan: Esenin.ru, the digital museum of Sergei Yesenin.

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